

SUMMARY

Introduction

The agriculture products have been a promising contributing factor to the National Gross Domestic Product (GDP). The report aims to find out how imports and exports of agriculture products have varied over a ten-year period, give insights, and provide possible caveats.

Method

The dataset used was collected from the Zambia Statistics Agency (ZamStats) and covers a ten-year period from 2013 to 2022. The analysis focuses on the yearly aggregate amounts in addition to the top ten imported and exported products.

Findings and Conclusion

The exports have been increasing for most part of the ten-year period. However, there has been noticeable decrease of Zambian Kwacha (K) 715,675,494.39, K894,765,307.05, K1,218,302,507.48 in 2014, 2017, and 2022 respectively. This is attributed to periods of draught. The top ten products within the ten-year period are Tobacco, other raw sugar cane, oil cake, maize excluding seeds, cotton, none stemmed tobacco, sweet biscuits, maize seeds, raw sugar cane, and beet sugar.

Imports have steadily risen with 2018 being the only year it fell by K192,298,419.52. This is the year cholera became an epidemic accompanied by a fading draught. The top ten products imported from 2013 to 2022 are urea, chemical fertilizer, frozen jack and horse mackerel, nitrogenous fertilizer, ammonium nitrate, other fertilizers, crude palm oil, crude soya bean oil, palm olein, and ammonium dihydrogen orthophosphate.

The top exports include cash crops as expected. The top imports include farming inputs. The total export, and import amount are roughly K76.65 billion, and K110.04 billion respectively. This results in a K33.39 billion deficit.

Recommendations

Firstly, the government should lower the price of fertilizer to allow more farmers to grow the outlined cash crops. Secondly, implement initiatives that teach farmers how to harvest the crops to ensure maximum harvest. Thirdly, provide machinery that can be used to scale cash crops like maize and tobacco to farmers that would not afford. Fourthly, the government should increase import tariffs to discourage mass importation. Lastly, tightening border security to prevent smuggling of agriculture products into or out of the country.

Caveats

First and foremost, the insights given are solely on the data set and might not reflect the trend in the future (2023 to the present). Secondly, only the top ten products imported and exported were considered which could show a bias towards the overall insights given above. Finally, the smuggling that may have been done throughout the ten-year period is not accounted for. Therefore, the total import and export amount could be more than what is highlighted above.